September 7, 2026

An Appeal to Money Transfer Operators and Payment Service Providers Serving Nepal

For a Waiver of Fees on Remittances to Nepal for Eight Weeks

It is with a sense of urgency that I appeal to **the leadership of all money transfer operators and payment service providers** to waive transaction fees on remittances sent to Nepal for a period of eight weeks, starting as soon as possible.

Following the catastrophic floods that struck Nepal on August 26, as of today, 2026, 1,350 people are confirmed dead and approximately 5,000 remain missing (including 600 foreign nationals from 34 countries). At least 41 bridges and 42 kilometers of road have been destroyed, 13 hydropower projects have suffered damage. Nepal's Finance Minister has estimated preliminary reconstruction costs at $4–5 billion, roughly a tenth of the economy.

Since the flood struck, we have seen an outpouring of support move through your networks. Nepal is among the top five remittance-dependent economies on earth. Remittances amount to over a quarter of GDP, or about $16 billion a year. More than 3.5 million Nepalis work abroad, and the Nepali diaspora numbers more than 6 million people, nearly one-fifth of the country's population. They are sending financial help to families in affected districts. In addition, people of many nationalities and charitable organizations are sending contributions to help flood-affected communities. They all use your payment services. Every one of these transfers will be worth more, and reach further, if it moves free of charge during the next two months.

Why This Matters to Nepali Families

Remittances provide a lifeline to Nepali households. Families use this income for groceries, medicines, and healthcare. In a flood-displaced household, it is the money that puts a meal on the table and pays for antibiotics a relief camp cannot supply. Even in normal times, a share of remittance income goes directly into housing. In the weeks ahead, remittances will help rebuild houses, school buildings, and village roads. They will help keep children in school, help businesses cope and livelihood investments recover by restocking destroyed shops, replacing lost livestock, and replanting flooded fields.

A Proven Precedent

Your industry has waived fees on remittances on several occasions following a natural disaster. Some of you waived remittance fees after Haiti's earthquake in January 2010, Pakistan's mega floods in September 2010, Typhoon Haiyan in the Philippines in November 2013, and the Nepal earthquake in April 2015. In the last instance, according to an expert estimate, the 2015 fee waiver was worth $40–50 million to Nepali families. Indeed, during the three months following the 2015 earthquake, remittances increased by 18%–26% compared with the months preceding the earthquake.

Your fee-waiver will be worth even more this year than in the second quarter of 2015. In the latest Nepali month (June-July), remittances were approximately $1.6 billion, larger than the previous month's

$1.3 billion. If remittances increase by 20% during this month and the next, they will amount to about $3.8 billion. Your gesture of a fee-waiver could translate into a contribution of $115-$154 million, assuming an average fee of 3%-4% for sending $200. (Actual fees can go up to 6-12% on some remittance services.) This contribution will be more than double the United Nations appeal to raise $50 million. Not only will this be a huge gift to vulnerable people who urgently need help, it will be timely and targeted, because the money will be disbursed directly by well-meaning migrant relatives. It is also highly likely that a fee waiver would further increase remittance volumes through your networks.

It is true that your agent networks, in Nepal and abroad, depend on transaction revenue, and that a full waiver represents a real near-term cost to your businesses. In the medium-term, however, you will gain larger volumes and earn enormous goodwill from your customers, many of whom have lost their homes, their harvests, and in too many cases, their loved ones.

With gratitude,

Dilip Ratha
CEO, Ratha Global